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The Poetic Spark: Fortuitous Juxtaposition and Lacanian Metaphor

In André Breton's 1924 *Manifesto of Surrealism*, he constructs a theory of poetics founded upon Freudian principles of the unconscious. The foundation of this theory relies on his conception of *psychic automatism*, a form of writing that relies on free association to draw out unexpected relations between signs by the chance of linguistic operation. Breton claims that through psychic automatism, one can generate a particularly intense "spark," potentially shedding light on unconscious desire by *fortuitously juxtaposing* distant yet associated images. However, many years after the founding of these Surrealist principles, Jacques Lacan, in his essay, "The Instance of the Letter in the Unconscious," challenges the idea that the juxtaposition of signified *images* generates this poetic spark. Through a revision of the Saussurian sign, wherein Lacan confounds the supposed relation to a word and its concept, he finds that the words do not consist of any given signified, but rather, that their underlying meaning *insists* as they're articulated in a continuous string of signifiers. In light of this discovery, he notes that the theory of Surrealist technique is in part wrong, due to Breton's belief in the juxtaposition of two "equally actualized signifiers," (422). The juxtaposition of images that Breton describes as generative of the "spark" is then complicated; rather than being a convergence of two signifieds, Lacan claims that the revealing spark is produced through *metaphor*, which he links directly to the primary and unconscious process of *condensation*. Due to Lacan's intervention, the Surrealist approach to the poetic spark requires a specific tweak, where instead of a simple fortuitous juxtaposition of two images, the second term is superimposed upon the condensed associations of the first, allowing for the first's barred signified to briefly flash into view.

In the first manifesto, Breton provides a precise description of the process of psychic automatism as *the* core technique of Surrealist practice:

SURREALISM, *n.* Psychic automatism in its pure state, by which one proposes to express—verbally, by means of the written word, or in any other manner—the actual functioning of thought. Dictated by thought, in the absence of any control exercised by reason, exempt from any aesthetic or moral concern (26).

Psychic automatism, which operates as the core modality of the Surrealist movement, is clearly presented here as a form of uncritical expression; by casting aside any rational concern, the technique attempts to express more directly than any other mode of writing, the unconscious structuring of human thought. This technique operates analogously to a mode of thought Freud had earlier coined in *The Interpretation of Dreams* called *self-observation*; here, instead of letting conscious rationality restrict the confines of thought, the person expressing themselves “need only take the trouble to suppress his critical faculty. If he succeeds in doing that, innumerable ideas come into his consciousness of which he could otherwise never have got hold,” (127). Freud claims that this mode of self-observation “makes it possible to interpret both his pathological ideas and his dream-structures,” (127). Through the suppression of reason, one might be able, as Breton believed, to bring the structure of expression as close “as possible akin to *spoken thought*,” (Breton 23). Thus, a loss of rational resistances during the flow of thought might be able to reveal what underlies conscious articulation, akin to the structures of dreams.

The use of self-observation and a relaxation of critical thought to shed light on the structure of unconscious processes might be best contextualized by the relation of *desire* to linguistic association. According to Laplanche and Pontalis’s analysis of Freud’s work on unconscious desire, a person’s search for a desired object is “entirely governed by [a]

relationship with signs,” in as much as desire is structured by a “hallucinatory reproduction of the perceptions which have become the signs” *associated* with the satisfaction of a previous need (482). When a person engages in the process of articulation, which brings about a kind of “search” for a particularly desired expression, this desire is in itself thus structured by associative relations between signs. However, in consciously articulated and reasoned expression, the integral connections and associative pathways that structure desire may be censored in some capacity. In the case of Surrealist psychic automatism, by allowing a free movement of association to occur within speech or writing, rather than a critical and rational articulation, the underlying, and structuring, force of unconscious desire can be translated into the realm of conscious thought.

The way in which this associative movement of desire might be captured by the articulation of uncritical language is best defined by Ferdinand de Saussure’s understanding of the relations between signs *in absentia* and *in praesentia*. According to Saussure’s definition of language *in absentia*, or associative relations “outside the context of discourse,” signs are organized like “a constellation, from which connected terms radiate *ad infinitum*,” where non-linear connections between signs can iterate an endless sequence of associations, akin to Freud’s claim that self-observation can give rise to innumerable ideas (121, 124). What is important about these associations is that they necessarily exist *outside* the context of discourse, whereas language *in praesentia*, or syntagmatic relations, are used *within* the context of discourse and are directly concerned with “combinations based on sequentiality,” (121). Psychic automatism then, as a form of discourse and thus syntagmatic, could be seen as an attempt to synthesize the non-linear and inexhaustible character of associative relations with the combinatory relations of contextualized speech. By attempting to express oneself within the

confines of speech yet refusing the logic and critical faculty that typically characterizes it, psychic automatism generates a sort of tension between these two poles of linguistic relations; it produces a dynamic structure akin to *spoken thought*.

This tension becomes essential when looking at how Breton saw psychic automatism as generative of the unconscious “spark,” one of the central goals of Surrealist poetics. Breton defines the way in which this spark is generated as follows:

It is, as it were, from the fortuitous juxtaposition of the two terms that a particular light has spring, *the light of the image*, to which we are infinitely sensitive. The value of the image depends on the beauty of the spark obtained; it is, consequently, a function of the difference of potential between the two conductors (37).

The conception of a *fortuitous juxtaposition* provides a clear foundation for the dynamic images generated through psychic automatism; fortuitous, on one hand, highlights the non-linear movement of signs *in absentia*, wherein one association leads to another based on a contingent sign led by desire, whereas their juxtaposition occurs as a result of their placement within a syntagmatic and combinatory structure. Secondly, the *distance* between the associated signs is in direct relation to the intensity of the image; Breton believed that by juxtaposing two particularly distant signs found through associative relations in a syntagmatic form, the relation between the two signs can generate a “suddenness from certain associations,” shedding a brief yet intense light on the darkness of unconscious desire (41). Through the tension produced in language by distant association and juxtaposition, the technique of psychic automatism functions as a sort of stress-test in revealing the limits of unconscious associative structures, and thus desire, to both the reader and writer of Surrealist works.

However, Breton's approach to shedding light on the unconscious relies on a particularly Saussurian conception of signification, given his interest in the function of the *images* generated by fortuitous juxtaposition. This is notably Saussurian given that the Saussurian sign is "dual in nature, comprising two elements," a *concept* and a *sound-pattern*, or a *signified* and *signifier* respectively, such as a psychological image of a tree that is connected by an associative link to the word "tree," (Saussure 66-7). This conception of signification, which seemingly underlies the project of Surrealism in its search for intense images, is one that psychoanalyst and linguist Jacques Lacan later confounded and revised. Lacan claimed that signifieds are in fact of a distinct order, "initially separated by a barrier resisting signification," that are impossible to reach "except by reference to another signification," (415). The signified concept, instead of being an image that simply exists as the flip side of a signifier or word, is only accessible through the use of other signifiers in the context of a syntagmatic structure, or in Lacanian terms, the *signifying chain*, to further define its meaning. Lacan most clearly defines this idea as the *insistence* of the signified meaning that slides underneath the precession of signifiers in a chain: "Whence we can say that it is in the chain of the signifier that meaning *insists*, but that none of the chain's elements *consists* in the signification it can provide at that very moment," (419). Thus, according to Lacan, this notion of signification is simply unworkable and unfounded, as signs do not simply produce a signified image.

Lacan, in the very same essay, directly lays pressure upon Breton's conception of fortuitous juxtaposition using these principles of language to more clearly delineate the source of this poetic spark of the unconscious. He notes that the experiment of psychic automatism was "marked by confusion because the doctrine behind it is false," explaining further that:

Metaphor's creative spark does not spring forth from the juxtaposition of two images, that is, of two equally actualized signifiers. It flashes between two signifiers, one of which has replaced the other by taking the other's place in the signifying chain, the occulted signifier remaining present by virtue of its (metonymic) connection to the rest of the chain (422).

In this instance, while Breton never directly states that the technique of fortuitous juxtaposition is a metaphoric process, Lacan's critiques of Breton's misunderstanding of signification still hold true, given that neither signifier can be directly exchanged for its signified concept; this then merits investigation into Lacan's claim that the substitutive component of metaphor, where one sign stands in for another, may in fact be more clearly generative of the Surrealist spark than Breton's imaginary juxtaposition.

Metaphor, to Lacan, is directly related to the Freudian process of condensation, wherein multiple cathexes or associations are merged into a single node. This definition clearly differentiates it from Breton's definition of fortuitous juxtaposition, which could be defined under Lacan's understanding of metonymy, which is linked to the process of displacement. According to Lacan, metonymy, wherein a part is taken for the whole, defines "the first aspect of the actual field the signifier constitutes, so that meaning may assume a place there," where meaning slides underneath chains of associated signifiers, with each signifier playing a part of the whole of their syntagmatic structure (421). Breton's fortuitous juxtaposition, which relies on the associative play of signification, despite its free-form nature that's capable of generating a productive distance between signs, necessarily keeps the signified, or the unconscious meaning of signification, trapped under the signifier. In this case, meaning is *displaced* as the signified is transferred from sign to sign. Metaphor, on the other hand, by allowing one sign to stand in for

another, operates as a form of *condensation*, wherein the superimposition of two signifiers produces an effect “that is poetic or creative” which “brings the signification in question into existence,” (429). Lacan conceptualizes this as the “passage of the signifier into the signified,” wherein the substitutive signifier, acting as a sort of ground for the figure of the previous barred signified, condenses and sheds light upon the first term’s complex network of associations (429). The poetic spark here, rather than a simple product of distant association, could be seen as the unconscious signified crossing its bar due to the secondary signifier that enters and superimposes a form upon it.

However, despite Lacan’s necessary revisions to Breton’s understanding of the poetic spark, the technique of psychic automatism and the principle of distant juxtaposition remain directly related to the spark’s intensity. Shortly before his intervention into the idea of fortuitous juxtaposition Lacan himself notes that:

Let us say that modern poetry and the Surrealist school led us to take a major step forward here by showing that any conjunction of two signifiers could just as easily constitute a metaphor, if an additional condition—that of the greatest disparity of the images signified—weren’t required for the production of the poetic spark (422).

This shows in some capacity, wherein Lacan saw the premise of fortuitous juxtaposition as potentially constitutive of a metaphoric process, despite Breton never defining it as such; the intensity of the poetic spark is only capable of being produced through associative distance, which was precisely the goal, and often the effect of psychic automatism, even if only explicitly defined metonymically and not metaphorically. According to Breton, when the difference between the two juxtaposed terms “exists only slightly, as in a comparison, the spark is lacking,”

(37). This weakness of conscious comparison is what precisely necessitates the metonymic procedure of psychic automatism as a means to generate distant-enough associations. When this technique moves beyond pure metonymic relation and produces “a dazzling weave of metaphors,” the associative webs of each barred signified are pulled into view by the contrast of their distant second, juxtaposing signifiers; these second terms then superimpose their own form on the initial, preceding terms in a continuous chain (Lacan 422). While Breton may have misunderstood the role of the signified within his own theory, the technique of psychic automatism and the generative distance of fortuitous juxtaposition, when applied to Lacanian metaphor, still operate as an effective, poetic means of shedding light on the structuring of the unconscious.

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